‘vow’ to give to the poor themselves.[11] It wasn’t money he was handing out, but a duty – and a sacrament.

A little over two months later, Sultan Khwaja – who was once pulled up from the moat outside Ahmedabad in a basket – arrived in court. He had been appointed leader of a Haj caravan, escorting pilgrims to Mecca, and was back with Arabian horses and tales of Akbar’s wonders.

One night, said Sultan Khwaja, as their ship sailed west in the dark, a boy fell ‘from the . . . deck into deep water’. It was impossible to see him in the pitch black, but his cries were all too clearly heard. Not knowing what else to do, Sultan Khwaja ‘made a vow to the world’s lord’, and sent some sailors in a dhow to look for the boy. Still, there was no sign of him for a long time, and the khwaja ‘was sunk in sorrow’. He should have had more faith in his vow. At midnight the boy was found.

‘Everyone,’ writes Abul Fazl, ‘put a ring of servitude to the emperor in his ear.’[12] It isn’t clear if he means the courtiers gathered around Akbar, listening to Sultan Khwaja’s tale, or the pilgrims and sailors aboard his ship. The idea of a ring of devotion, however, was crystal clear: it was a symbol of enslavement, in this case of spiritual enslavement, to a saint or a pir.[13]

Some six months later, on a Friday in June 1579, Akbar climbed up to the pulpit in the mosque at Fatehpur and delivered the sermon. The *khutba* was always read in the name of the sovereign, of course – *khutba-u-sikka*, sermon and coin, were twin markers of sovereignty, in fact – but never by him. Akbar, however, had learnt that not only the Prophet, but also the four Abbasid Caliphs, and Akbar’s own ancestors, Timur and Ulugh Beg, had preached their own sermons, and was keen to try it. As Nizamuddin, most dispassionate of Akbar’s chroniclers, writes, ‘His Majesty therefore felt it to be his duty to carry into practice . . . the custom observed by the Khalifas and Imams.’[14] Badauni is less circumspect: Akbar read the khutba because ‘he held it to be an insufferable burden to be subordinate to any one’.

‘[T]he pulpit was honoured by the [emperor’s] sky-touching feet’, writes Abul Fazl, and Akbar was well aware, it seems, that he was stepping into terrain as unknown and dangerous as the forests of the east or the deserts of the west, into the well-guarded realm, in fact, of his court clergy.

Fittingly enough, given the family’s embittered history with Makhdum-ul-Mulk and his coterie, it was Abul Fazl’s brother, Faizi, who had composed a